

they might surprise Nepalis again by running the government successfully," says Kunda Dixit, editor of *Nepali Times*.

But the task ahead is unlikely to be a bed of roses for the red warriors. It may turn out to be tougher than the 'integration' of Maoist combatants into the national army. The immediate challenge will be to tackle the fuel crisis and soaring food prices, besides bringing tourists back to Nepal. Another important factor will be the manner in which monarchy will be relegated to history—something uppermost in the minds of people. With the Nepalis giving a massive mandate to the ex-rebels, who had waged their war with the avowed goal of abolishing monarchy and establishing a republic, the days of the 240-year-old Shah

dynasty are numbered. All major parties have changed their party statutes in favour of a federal republic. The very first sitting of the assembly that has to convene within 21 days of the declaration of election results (expected by the last week of April) is set to formalise the end of monarchy. Political and diplomatic circles in Kathmandu say CPN (M) chairman Pushpa Karnal Dahal, a.k.a. Prachanda has already started discussions to provide a graceful and dignified exit to King Gyanendra and members of the royal family. Maoist party ideologue Baburam Bhattarai has said the King has to vacate the Narayanhiti Palace after the first meet of the constituent assembly.

Bhattarai says there is no reason for India to be apprehensive about the Maoists' victory. Soon after his victory was announced from the Kathmandu constituency, chairman Prachanda had urged the international community not to doubt his party's commitment to competitive politics. Specifically mentioning India and China, he said they would maintain cordial relation with both the neigh-

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THE FINAL BOW: Gyanendra is now looking at a dignified exit

bours. Bhattarai, who has publicly spoken about renegotiating the "old and unequal" 1950 Treaty of Peace and Friendship with India, says the party would hold discussions with the Indian government but is not in a hurry. The treaty, a precursor to trade and transit treaties between the two countries, speaks of "special relations" between the two countries and is considered unfavourable to Nepal by many. India has proposed scrapping it if Nepal wishes to do so. Either side can give a year's notice for its annulment. "That was more of election rhetoric by the Maoists just like the CPN (UML) which too insisted on reviewing the treaty," points out Professor Lok Raj Baral, former Nepali ambassador to India.

Already some high-level contacts between the two sides have been established. While the Indian envoy to Nepal Shiv Shankar Mukherjee has met Prachanda, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee also spoke to him over the phone. Sources say a visit by Prachanda to New Delhi is on the cards. "We will work with the results," remarked Mukherjee. South Block insiders say the Indian strategy will be to work its channels of communication with Maoists leaders to convey that the destinies of the two countries are intertwined. "Both India and Nepal need each other, and we will work with the new Nepali leadership to move forward our friendly relations," remarked a South Block official. For India, a gain from this electoral outcome is that the insta-

bility in Nepal—which had a direct bearing on the security of India—may end. In fact it may use the Maoist victory to send out a message to its own naxalite groups, that laying down arms and joining the mainstream has advantages as the Nepal experience has demonstrated.

India will have to convince the new leadership, many of whom were groomed in India, that Kathmandu's interests lie in forging closer ties with Delhi. Besides, it will have to ensure that its diplomatic reflexes are finetuned to balance the Chinese influence in Nepal,

which may increase with their ideological bedfellows in the saddle in Kathmandu. Since India controls the economic lifeline of Nepal and is its biggest trade partner, the Maoist-led government can ill afford to antagonise Delhi. In fact, the Maoist victory is an opportunity for India to revisit and correct its Nepal policy. Missing this opportunity could be disastrous.

